Year 3 English | The Missing Key

Learn and notice | A problem, connected actions and a solution

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Name: _____ Date: _____

Learning intention

I can write a story with a clear beginning, connected events and an ending that solves the problem.

Read the model: a different missing object

The Missing Map

At the school picnic, Sam reached into his pocket for the treasure-hunt map. His pocket was empty. Without the map, his team could not find the next clue.

First, Sam checked beside the lunch table, but only a paper cup lay there. He remembered taking off his jacket near the oval. He hurried back and searched its pockets.

The folded map was tucked inside the jacket. Sam ran to his waiting team. They followed the next clue together, and Sam zipped the map safely into his pocket.

Writing detective

1. What problem stops Sam's team?
2. Why does Sam search his jacket?
3. How does the ending solve the original problem?

Which ending fits? Circle A or B and explain.

A. Sam found the map and his team continued the treasure hunt.
B. A spaceship appeared and took everyone to the moon.
Which ending follows the events already in the story? Why?

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Think and plan | Make your own story choices

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Your prompt: The Missing Key

Write a story in which a key goes missing. Decide what it opens and why finding it matters. Your character must try to solve the problem.
Audience: classmates. Purpose: entertain them with a connected story.

Beginning: who, where and what matters?

Character: _____ Place: _____
What does the key open? Why is it needed?

Problem: what happens to the key?

Give the reader a clue about when or where it might have been lost.

Attempt 1: what does the character try?

What happens? The first attempt does not have to work.

Attempt 2: how does the next action follow?

Use a clue, memory or result from the first attempt.

Ending: how is the problem solved?

Where is the key found, or what other believable solution works?
What can the character finally do?

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Write your draft | Help your reader follow the story

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Write The Missing Key

Use your plan, but change it if you get a better idea. Start a new paragraph when the story moves to a new stage. Keep the tense mostly consistent.
Useful words: searched, remembered, slipped, finally. Use only words that fit.

My story draft

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Edit and improve | Show one change that helps the reader

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Read your draft aloud

[ ] My beginning introduces the character and situation.
[ ] The problem explains why the key matters.
[ ] Each action follows from what happened before.
[ ] My ending solves the problem introduced in the story.

Make one connection clearer

Before: Zara looked by the gate. She went to the shed.
After: Zara looked by the gate, but the key was not there. Then she remembered leaving her bag in the shed, so she went to check it.
Notice: The revision explains why Zara moves to the shed.
Find a jump in your story. Add a clue or explanation that connects the events.

My before-and-after revision

Original sentence(s):

Improved version:

Explain your improvement

My change helps the reader understand _____

Final writing detective check

[ ] I checked capitals, full stops and spelling.
[ ] I used simple paragraphs to group related events.
[ ] I can explain one meaningful change I made.

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Teacher and parent guide | Answers, support and evidence of learning

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Teach in two short sessions

Suggested time: 20–25 minutes to read, discuss and plan; 20–30 minutes to draft and revise. Adjust for the learner.
Read page 1 together. Rehearse the story aloud using page 2, write on page 3, then improve on page 4. Extra writing paper may be used.

Answers to page 1

1. The map is missing, so the team cannot find the next clue.
2. Sam remembers taking off his jacket near the oval.
3. Finding the map allows the treasure hunt to continue.

Ending choice: A follows the existing problem and events. B introduces an unrelated event without resolving the missing map. Accept equivalent explanations in the student's own words.

Support, challenge and parent coaching

Support: Adult reads instructions. Rehearse orally; use First / Then / Finally if helpful. Record any scribing or prompting.
Challenge: Plant an early clue and use it in the solution. Keep the story connected rather than adding extra events.
Ask: "Why does your character do that next?" Let the child choose the revision.

Observe the skill, then check transfer

Record Not yet / With support / Independently for:

- Beginning makes the situation clear.
- Actions follow logically from the problem.
- Ending resolves the problem.
- Paragraphs, sentences and editing help the reader.

For later independent practice, use "The Lost Ticket", hide the model and record how much help was given. These are practice criteria, not NAPLAN scores.

Curriculum and NAPLAN preparation scope

Supports selected aspects of AC9E3LY06: planning, creating and editing imaginative writing, grouping ideas in simple paragraphs and maintaining tense.
Guided narrative practice for NAPLAN preparation; not an official or full timed test.
Sources: ACARA Year 3 "Narrative - Oceania"; nap.edu.au narrative writing guide.

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